

Capture the raptors on film at CRC

If you're a wildlife or nature photographer — amateur or otherwise — it's time to get clicking!

Carolina Raptor Center (CRC) in Huntersville offers a rare opportunity to photograph birds of prey up close in natural settings during their annual Photo Wild! contest, March 29, 30 and April 5.

Open to both professional and amateur photographers, the contest offers 35 pre-registered shutterbugs the chance to photograph owls, eagles, hawks, falcons and other CRC raptors during specified hours, then submit up to three framed for judging.

Winners will be selected in categories of Best Personality, Best Black & White, Best Color, Best Action, Best Composition and Best in Show.

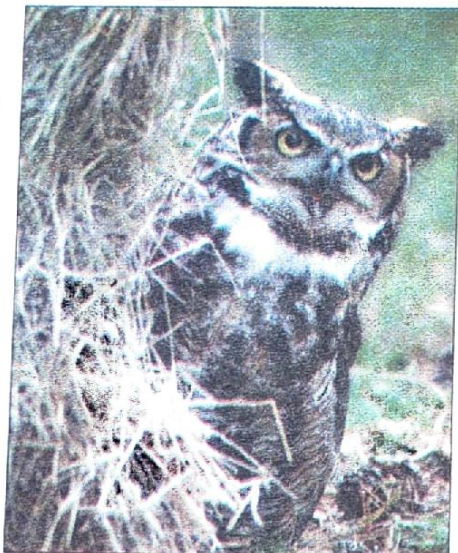
Photos will be displayed on the CRC Web site, annual calendar and during the public Photo Wild! Gala and Benefit Auction May 3, 6-9 p.m. Participants who contribute photographs receive two complimentary tickets to the event.

All photos become property of CRC for marketing and promotional purposes. All photographers must register with Tanya Morgan at 704-875-6521, ext. 212.

Registration is \$65 per member; \$90 per non-member and \$40 per student, limited to 35 photographers per day. Early registration is encouraged.

Proceeds from CRC's silent auction support environmental education and the conservation of birds of prey through public education, research and the rehabilitation of injured and orphaned raptors.

Photo Wild! isn't the only noteworthy event at CRC in coming weeks. For the first time, CRC will "Go Green!" on Saturday, March 15, noon-4 p.m., celebrating St. Patrick's Day with a new festival that features recycled arts and crafts, games for



COURTESY CRC

This photograph by Ann Gaal won honorable mention for best personality in last year's PhotoWild! competition.

kids, bird shows and a group of environmental organizations from all over Charlotte that will share ideas and supplies to make life more eco-friendly.

In addition, upcoming weekends are packed with programs about raptors:

- "Behind the Scenes Tours," Saturday and Sunday, March 1-2 at 2 p.m., offer tours of CRC's bird hospital showing the

care an injured raptor receives, from initial exam to strengthening wings in outdoor flight cages. Pre-registration appreciated and extra fees apply.

- "Weathering Programs: Mating and Courtship Behavior" interprets birds' sky dances, wing clapping and tumbling through the air and is free with regular admission.

- "Meet the Keeper" programs — also free with regular admission — on Saturday and Sunday, March 8-9 at 2 p.m., introduce those who care for raptors and answer questions about the bird's natural behavior and personality.

- "Trail Trivia Talks" Saturday and Sunday,

March 15 and 16 at 2 p.m. Take guided tours down a wooded nature trail with facts and stories about CRC, resident raptors and the environment. This program is free with regular admission.

- For beginner and intermediate level rehabilitators and other wildlife professionals, an in-depth "Raptor Rehabilitation Seminar," March 14-16, 8:30 a.m.-4:30

p.m., combines lectures, multimedia presentations and hands-on practice including raptor identification, capture and handling techniques, internal anatomy, tail wraps, indoor housing, diet, recording keeping, basic bandaging and eye exams. Pre-registration and deposit required. The seminar costs \$135 per day for CRC members; \$155 per day for non-members, with multi-session discounts available. Contact Mathias Englemann 704-875-6521, ext. 108, or mathiasenglemann@carolinaraptorcenter.org to register.

CRC hours are Monday-Saturday 10 a.m.-5 p.m. and Sunday noon-5 p.m. Admission is \$7 for adults, \$6 for seniors, \$5 for students, and free for children younger than five when accompanied by an adult or CRC member. Group admission rates (15 people or more) are \$3.50 per person. Group reservations must be made one week in advance.

CRC is an outdoor facility and visitors are encouraged to dress for weather. For the protection of resident raptors, no pets are allowed on CRC premises or nature trails. For directions and more information, visit www.carolinaraptorcenter.org or call 704-875-6521.

— Ann Fletcher



• **Joel Shapiro Exhibition:** View works from a leading figure in contemporary sculpture through Feb. 29. The exhibit will be at the Davidson College Beik Visual Arts Center and will be open from 10-5 weekdays and

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